The L_{RCC8} Undecidability Proof Does Not Transfer to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$: Concrete vs. Abstract Semantics and the Coincidence Obstruction

Claude (Anthropic) and Michael Wessel*

April 2026

Abstract

Lutz and Wolter [1] proved that the modal logic L_{RCC8} is undecidable by reducing the $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$ domino tiling problem to satisfiability over topological models. A natural question is whether this undecidability transfers to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$, the description logic with RCC8 roles and composition-table semantics introduced by Wessel [3].

We show that it does not. The reduction relies on the geometry of regular closed sets in $\mathbb{R}^2$ to enforce a *grid coincidence condition* ($R_X \circ R_Y = R_Y \circ R_X$) that the abstract composition-table semantics of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ cannot guarantee. This coincidence obstruction was first identified by Wessel in 2002, who constructed explicit RCC8 grid models but showed that no concept term can force the coincidence at the level of abstract models.

The analysis reveals that Wessel's 2002/2003 technical report anticipated the key technical ingredients of the Lutz–Wolter proof—the even-odd chain construction, the grid encoding via TPP/NTPP, and the identification of the coincidence gap as the decisive obstacle—three to four years before their LMCS publication. The decidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ remains open.

1. Introduction

The description logics $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ and $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ were introduced by Wessel [2, 3] as extensions of $\mathcal{ALCI}$ with spatially interpreted roles. In these logics, every pair of domain elements is related by exactly one RCC base relation, the role box is fixed by the RCC composition table, and the identity relation is the only reflexive role (strong EQ semantics). Wessel proved $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC1}$, $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC2}$, and $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC3}$ decidable, and established lower complexity bounds for the remaining two: PSpace-hard for $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ and ExpTime-hard for $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ [3]. The decidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ and $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ was left as an open problem and remains open to this day.

Independently, Lutz and Wolter [1] studied *modal logics of topological relations*, denoted L_{RCC8}, L_{RCC5}, etc. These logics have the same *syntax* as the $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC}$ family but are interpreted over *topological models*: the domain elements are regular closed subsets of a topological space

*Michael Wessel introduced the $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC}$ family and identified the coincidence obstruction in [3, 2]. Claude performed the comparative analysis and wrote this report. Contact: miacwess@gmail.com.

(typically $\mathbb{R}^n$), and the RCC relations have their standard topological definitions. They proved L_{RCC8} undecidable by reducing the $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$ domino tiling problem [1].

The syntactic coincidence naturally raises the question:

Does the undecidability of L_{RCC8} imply the undecidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$?

We show that the answer is **no**. The core of the argument is the *coincidence obstruction*: the Lutz–Wolter reduction requires that certain pairs of regions coincide (to close the grid), and this coincidence is guaranteed by the geometry of $\mathbb{R}^2$ but not by the composition table alone. Wessel identified exactly this obstruction in [3], Section 4.4.3, and gave explicit constructions showing that the grid can be built as an RCC8 network but cannot be *enforced* by a concept term in the abstract semantics.

The purpose of this note is threefold:

1. To make the non-transfer argument precise (Section 5).
2. To document the technical priority of the constructions in Wessel [3] relative to Lutz–Wolter [1] (Section 7).
3. To discuss what the comparison tells us about the decidability status of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ (Section 8).

2. Preliminaries

2.1. RCC8 base relations and composition table

RCC8 distinguishes eight base relations between regions:

$$\mathcal{N}_{\mathcal{R}8} = \{DC,\, EC,\, PO,\, EQ,\, TPP,\, NTPP,\, TPPI,\, NTPPI\}.$$

DC (disconnected) and EC (externally connected) refine DR; TPP (tangential proper part) and $NTPP$ (non-tangential proper part) refine PP. The composition table $\mathsf{comp}(R, S) \subseteq \mathcal{N}_{\mathcal{R}8}$ is defined for all pairs $R, S \in \mathcal{N}_{\mathcal{R}8}$ and captures which base relations are possible for a pair (a, c) given that $R(a, b)$ and $S(b, c)$ hold.

A key property of the composition table is:

$$TPPI \circ TPPI \sqsubseteq TPPI \sqcup NTPPI, \tag{1}$$
$$TPPI \circ NTPPI \sqsubseteq NTPPI, \tag{2}$$
$$NTPPI \circ TPPI \sqsubseteq NTPPI, \tag{3}$$
$$NTPPI \circ NTPPI \sqsubseteq NTPPI. \tag{4}$$

These entries mean that the composition of the *transitive orbit* of $TPPI$ with itself is contained in the transitive orbit plus $NTPPI$: in other words, $NTPPI$ is the "non-immediate" part of the transitive closure of $TPPI$. This is what allows the distinction between *direct* and *indirect* containment—a distinction unavailable in RCC5, where $PP = TPP \cup NTPP$ is a single relation.

2.2. $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$: abstract composition-table semantics

An $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ interpretation is a pair $\mathcal{I} = (\Delta^{\mathcal{I}}, \cdot^{\mathcal{I}})$ where:

- $\Delta^{\mathcal{I}}$ is a non-empty set (the domain);
- every pair (d, e) with $d \neq e$ is assigned exactly one base relation $R \in \mathcal{N}_{\mathcal{R}8} \setminus \{EQ\}$, and $EQ^{\mathcal{I}} = \mathrm{Id}(\Delta^{\mathcal{I}})$ (strong EQ semantics);
- the role box (composition-table constraints) is satisfied: for all $R, S \in \mathcal{N}_{\mathcal{R}8}$, $R^{\mathcal{I}} \circ S^{\mathcal{I}} \subseteq \bigcup_{T \in \mathsf{comp}(R,S)} T^{\mathcal{I}}$;
- concepts are interpreted as in $\mathcal{ALCI}$: $(\exists R.C)^{\mathcal{I}} = \{d \mid \exists e.\ \langle d, e\rangle \in R^{\mathcal{I}} \wedge e \in C^{\mathcal{I}}\}$, etc.

The key point: an $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ model is an *abstract complete graph* with RCC8 edge-coloring satisfying the composition table. No topological realization is required.

2.3. L_{RCC8}: topological semantics

An L_{RCC8} model [1] interprets formulas over regular closed subsets of a topological space (typically $\mathbb{R}^n$). The RCC8 relations are defined topologically:

- $DC(a, b)$ iff $a \cap b = \emptyset$;
- $EC(a, b)$ iff $a \cap b \neq \emptyset$ but $a^\circ \cap b^\circ = \emptyset$;
- $PO(a, b)$ iff $a^\circ \cap b^\circ \neq \emptyset$, $a \not\subseteq b$, $b \not\subseteq a$;
- $TPP(a, b)$ iff $a \subsetneq b$ and $a \cap \partial b \neq \emptyset$;
- $NTPP(a, b)$ iff $a \subsetneq b$ and $a \cap \partial b = \emptyset$;

and symmetrically for $TPPI$, $NTPPI$, and EQ.

Every topological model is an $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ model (the composition table holds in any topological space), but not every $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ model is topologically realizable. Formally:
Observation 1. *For any concept/formula φ:*

$$\varphi \text{ is } L_{RCC8}\text{-satisfiable} \implies \varphi \text{ is } \mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}\text{-satisfiable.}$$

The converse does not hold in general.

3. The even-odd chain: functional successors via TPP/NTPP

Both Wessel [3] and Lutz–Wolter [1] exploit the TPP/NTPP distinction to create *functional successor chains* within RCC8 models. The construction deserves careful comparison.

3.1. Wessel's construction (2002/2003)

In [3], Section 4.4.2, Wessel defines the concept `infinite_even_odd_chain`:

$$\mathit{even} \sqcap (\mathit{even} \to \forall TPPI.\mathit{odd}) \sqcap \forall R_*.\big((\mathit{even} \leftrightarrow \neg \mathit{odd}) \sqcap (\mathit{even} \to \forall TPPI.\mathit{odd}) \sqcap (\mathit{odd} \to \forall TPPI.\mathit{even})\big) \sqcap \cdots$$

(simplified; see [3], p. 39 for the full definition). Each node alternates between *even* and *odd*. Since (1)–(4) imply $(TPPI^{\mathcal{I}})^+ - TPPI^{\mathcal{I}} \subseteq NTPPI^{\mathcal{I}}$, a node can distinguish its *direct* $TPPI$-successor from all *indirect* ones by parity. This gives a *functional* successor relation: each node has exactly one $TPPI$-successor of the opposite parity.

Wessel then uses this chain to encode a **binary n-bit counter**, showing that $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ models can be forced to have paths of length $\geq 2^n$, thereby proving:

Theorem 2 (Wessel [3], Section 4.4.2)**.** *Concept satisfiability in $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ is* ExpTime*-hard.*

3.2. Lutz–Wolter's construction (2006)

In [1], the same idea appears as follows. An infinite sequence of regions $r_1, r_2, r_3, \ldots$ is ordered by *ntpp*. Regions are marked alternately with $a \wedge b$ and $a \wedge \neg b$, connected via *tpp*. The *next* operator is defined as:

$$\mathsf{3}^+\varphi \;=\; \langle \mathit{tppi}\rangle(a \wedge \neg b \wedge \langle \mathit{tppi}\rangle(a \wedge b \wedge \varphi))$$

which skips one intermediate region to reach the next grid position. This is the same functional-successor construction, using *tpp*/*ntpp* in place of $TPP/NTPP$ and $a \wedge b$ / $a \wedge \neg b$ in place of *even*/*odd*.

Lutz and Wolter credit this technique to Marx and Reynolds [4] and Reynolds and Zakharyaschev [5]. They do not reference Wessel's even-odd chain construction [3], despite citing Wessel's earlier workshop paper [2].

Remark 3. *Wessel's even-odd chain appears in his DL Workshop 2001 paper [2] and is developed more fully in the 2002/2003 technical report [3]. The technique of distinguishing TPP from $NTPP$ to obtain functional successors in an RCC8 logic is independently present in Marx–Reynolds [4] for temporal logics. The application to RCC8 description logics—including the binary counter and the* ExpTime*-hardness proof—is Wessel's contribution.*

4. The grid construction and the coincidence obstruction

Both Wessel and Lutz–Wolter attempt to encode a two-dimensional grid $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$ in RCC8 models, in order to reduce the domino tiling problem. The grid requires:

(G1) Nodes represent grid positions.

(G2) Each node has a unique horizontal successor (R_X) and a unique vertical successor (R_Y), both extractable from TPP.

(G3) **Coincidence condition:** $R_X \circ R_Y = R_Y \circ R_X$. That is, the east-of-north equals the north-of-east.

4.1. Wessel's grid construction and the obstruction (2002/2003)

In [3], Section 4.4.3, Wessel:

1. Defines the domino system and the requirements for a grid concept C_{grid} (p. 41).
2. Constructs explicit RCC8 networks isomorphic to $n \times n$ grids for arbitrary n (Figure 10, p. 42). The construction uses TPP for horizontal and vertical successors, PO for within-row relationships, and $NTPP$ for indirect containment. These networks are composition-consistent.
3. Identifies the **coincidence obstruction** (Figure 11, p. 43): when a node x has two TPP-successors y (horizontal) and another (vertical), and y has a TPP-successor z (vertical), and the vertical path from x leads to z' (horizontal), then enforcing $z = z'$ requires $EQ(z, z')$. But the composition table allows

$$\{PO, EQ, TPP, NTPP, TPPI, NTPPI\}$$

   as possible relations between z and z'—there is no way to force EQ using concept terms alone.
4. Concludes (p. 43–44):

   > "Even though these infinite models do exist, we have found no way to *enforce* the depicted model(s) by means of a concept term."

5. Observes that adding a hybrid logic binding operator $\downarrow$ would immediately yield undecidability, confirming that the coincidence condition is the *precise boundary.*

4.2. Lutz–Wolter's grid construction (2006)

In [1], Section 8, Lutz and Wolter solve the coincidence problem—but only in the *topological* setting. They introduce additional "c-regions" connected via *tpp* to implement a "go right" function in the grid. The grid coincidence (G3) is enforced because:

- In a topological space, $TPP(a, b)$ means $a \subsetneq b$ with $a \cap \partial b \neq \emptyset$. The containment structure of regions in $\mathbb{R}^2$ (or $\mathbb{R}^n$ for $n \geq 1$) is rigid enough that the "go right then go up" and "go up then go right" paths are forced to reach the same region.
- This rigidity is a consequence of the topological structure, not of the composition table. The composition table is a *necessary* condition for topological realizability but not a *sufficient* one: there exist infinite composition-consistent RCC8 networks that are not realizable in any topological space.

The result is:
Theorem 4 (Lutz–Wolter [1], Theorem 8.2)**.** *Satisfiability of L_{RCC8} formulas (over topological models in $\mathbb{R}^n$ for any $n \geq 1$) is undecidable.*

5. Why the undecidability does not transfer

We now make the non-transfer argument precise.

Proposition 5. *The undecidability of L_{RCC8}-satisfiability does not imply the undecidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$-satisfiability. Specifically, the Lutz–Wolter reduction from the $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$ domino tiling problem cannot be lifted from topological to abstract models.*

Proof. Let $\mathcal{D} = (\mathcal{D}, \mathcal{H}, \mathcal{V})$ be a domino system, and let $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ be the Lutz–Wolter formula encoding $\mathcal{D}$. The reduction requires:

$$\mathcal{D} \text{ tiles } \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N} \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad C_{\mathcal{D}} \text{ is satisfiable}$$

in the relevant model class.

Soundness ($\Rightarrow$): If $\mathcal{D}$ tiles, then $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ has a topological model (the grid of regions in $\mathbb{R}^2$). By Observation 1, it also has an abstract model. So $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ is $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$-satisfiable. This direction transfers.

Completeness ($\Leftarrow$): If $\mathcal{D}$ does *not* tile, we need $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ to be unsatisfiable in the relevant model class. For L_{RCC8}, every model is topological, and the topological rigidity forces the grid coincidence condition (G3). Therefore every L_{RCC8}-model of $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ is (isomorphic to) a valid tiling, so L_{RCC8}-unsatisfiability follows.

For $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$, the situation is different. An abstract model of $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ need not satisfy (G3): the "east-of-north" and "north-of-east" elements z and z' may be distinct, with $R(z, z') \in \{PO, TPP, NTPP, TPPI, NTPPI\}$ (any relation permitted by the composition table). Such a model satisfies the concept term $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ without encoding a valid tiling—it is a "spurious" model where the two-dimensional grid structure unravels.

Therefore, $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ being $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$-satisfiable does not imply that $\mathcal{D}$ tiles, and the completeness direction fails. □

Remark 6. *The failure is not merely a gap in the proof that might be closed by a cleverer encoding. It reflects a* structural *difference between the two semantics: topological models have geometric rigidity that abstract models lack. Any domino reduction to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ would need to enforce grid coincidence using only the composition table—but as Wessel showed [3], the table allows too many options at the coincidence point (Figure 11).*

Remark 7. *The situation is structurally parallel to RCC5. Lutz and Wolter [1] prove $L_{RCC5}(RS^{\exists})$ undecidable (via a reduction from $S5^3$ satisfiability), where $RS^{\exists}$ denotes region structures with supremum closure. This does not transfer to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5} = L_{RCC5}(RS)$ because abstract $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ models need not have suprema. Lutz and Wolter explicitly acknowledge this: $L_{RCC5}(RS)$ is "one of the most intriguing open problems" suggested by their work [1]. Both non-transfer arguments have the same shape: the concrete semantics (topological for RCC8, supremum closure for RCC5) provides constraints beyond the composition table that the abstract semantics lacks.*

6. Could the reduction be adapted?

One might ask: can the Lutz–Wolter encoding be modified to work in the abstract setting? We consider three natural approaches.

6.1. Using nominals to force coincidence

As Wessel observes [3], $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ can express nominals: the concept $\boxed{i} \sqcap \forall R_D.\neg\boxed{i}$ (where $R_D = \mathcal{N}_{\mathcal{R}} \setminus \{EQ\}$) forces $\boxed{i}^{\mathcal{I}}$ to be a singleton. One could attempt to name the "diagonal" node z and z' with the same nominal, forcing $z = z'$.

But this works only for *finitely many* grid positions. The domino problem requires an *infinite* grid, and a concept term contains only finitely many nominals. As Wessel notes (p. 43–44): "this identification [...] works only for a finite number of successors, since we can only exploit a finite number of nominals."

Adding a hybrid logic binding operator $\downarrow$ (which can introduce fresh nominals dynamically) would solve the problem—but also immediately yield undecidability, as this goes beyond $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ [3].

6.2. Exploiting patchwork to close the gap

The RCC8 composition table satisfies a *patchwork property*: every path-consistent atomic constraint network is globally consistent [6]. Could this be used to argue that all abstract models satisfying $C_{\mathcal{D}}$ must be grid-like?

No. Patchwork guarantees that a *consistent atomic network can be extended*, but it does not force two nodes to be *equal*. The coincidence condition requires $z = z'$ (i.e., $EQ(z, z')$), not just consistency of the relation between them. Patchwork is a tool for *soundness* (building models), not for *rigidity* (constraining models).

6.3. Using the alternating-type trick

In [7], we observe that $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ can distinguish a role from its transitive orbit: $\forall TPP.C$ affects only direct TPP-successors, while $\forall NTPP.C$ affects indirect ones. This allows an *alternating-type trick*: a concept $\forall NTPP.D$ broadcasts D to all indirect successors, and D can constrain the types of nodes reached two or more steps along the $TPPI$-chain.

This gives $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ a limited form of "global constraint propagation." But propagation is *monotonic* (constraints accumulate, they cannot be consumed), which is insufficient for the unbounded synchronization required by general domino tiling. The alternating-type trick provides a 1-dimensional ladder but not a 2-dimensional grid.

6.4. A concrete $TPPI/NTPPI$ grid attempt

To make the obstruction completely explicit, we write out a concrete $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ concept that attempts to encode a 2D grid using the $TPPI/NTPPI$ distinction. The construction is the natural RCC8 lift of the failed RCC5 domino attempt in our main paper [7]: there, $\mathsf{comp}(PPI, PPI) = \{PPI\}$ makes PPI-chains transitive and the ancestral isolation universal propagates to every deeper descendant. The RCC8 refinement $\mathsf{comp}(TPPI, TPPI) = \{TPPI, NTPPI\}$ is non-transitive, which suggests the collapse can be avoided. We show that while this is locally true, the *coincidence obstruction* of §4 reappears at the grid level.

Schema. Let Corner be a *local* isolation marker placed directly on the colored grandchildren (rather

than as an ancestral universal, so it cannot propagate transitively through recursion):

$$\mathsf{Corner} \;=\; \bigwedge_{R \in \{DC,EC,PO,TPP,NTPP,TPPI,NTPPI\}} \forall R.(\neg C \sqcap \neg D).$$

Define

$$\begin{aligned} X \;&= \exists TPPI.\exists TPPI.(C \sqcap \mathsf{Corner}) \;\sqcap\; \exists TPPI.\exists TPPI.(D \sqcap \mathsf{Corner}) \\ &\quad \sqcap\; \forall TPPI.(\neg C \sqcap \neg D) \;\sqcap\; \forall TPPI.X. \end{aligned}$$

The conjunct $\forall TPPI.(\neg C \sqcap \neg D)$ forces the corner relation $x \to z$ to be $NTPPI$ (not $TPPI$), via $\mathsf{comp}(TPPI, TPPI) = \{TPPI, NTPPI\}$.

Level 1 is satisfiable, with direct/indirect successors genuinely distinguished. Without recursion, x has two $TPPI$-children y_1, y_2 and a single $NTPPI$-grandchild z reached along both $TPPI$-$TPPI$ chains. The RCC5 EQ-collapse argument carries over: $z_1 \in C \sqcap \mathsf{Corner}$ and $z_2 \in D \sqcap \mathsf{Corner}$ are mutual non-EQ neighbors only if Corner is violated, so under strong-EQ semantics $z_1 = z_2 = z$. Crucially, z is $NTPPI$-related to x while y_1, y_2 are $TPPI$-related—the direct vs. indirect distinction survives. This is a genuine refinement over the RCC5 attempt in [7], where PP/PPI-chains cannot express such a distinction.

Level 2 collapses via the coincidence obstruction. Adding $\forall TPPI.X$: the $TPPI$-child y satisfies X, producing its own corner $w \in C \sqcap D \sqcap \mathsf{Corner}$ at $NTPPI$-distance from y, and hence at $NTPPI$-distance from x via $\mathsf{comp}(TPPI, NTPPI) = \{NTPPI\}$. Now z (the corner of x) and w (the corner of y) are distinct *intended* grid positions, but as elements of the model they are related by some RCC8 base relation. Since z carries Corner, every non-EQ neighbor of z lies in $\neg C \sqcap \neg D$. But $w \in C \sqcap D$. Therefore $z = w$ under strong-EQ semantics. Iterating the recursion, **all corners of the intended grid coincide at a single point**—the grid collapses to 1D.

Diagnosis. The RCC5 collapse is a *transitive-propagation* failure: the grandparent universal fires on great-grandchildren because $\mathsf{comp}(PPI, PPI) = \{PPI\}$. Moving the isolation into a local Corner marker and using the non-transitive composition $\mathsf{comp}(TPPI, TPPI) = \{TPPI, NTPPI\}$ eliminates that pathway. But a different obstruction takes over: the composition table permits any of $\{PO, EQ, TPP, NTPP, TPPI, NTPPI\}$ between two corners at distinct intended grid coordinates, and nothing in the concept language rules out EQ. The local Corner marker then *forces* the EQ-merge. This is exactly the composition-table gap that Wessel's Figure 11 identifies in [3] (cf. §4): abstract RCC8 does not carry the rigidity needed to keep distinct grid cells distinct.

Remark 8. *This concrete attempt sharpens the non-transfer story. The $TPPI/NTPPI$ distinction does provide something the RCC5 case lacks—a local direct/indirect separator at level 2—and it does avoid the specific transitive-propagation failure mode of the RCC5 attempt. But it does* not *close the 2D coincidence gap. Lutz–Wolter's L_{RCC8} reduction resolves the gap topologically: geometric boundary inclusions force north-of-east to coincide with east-of-north* without *causing distant corners to merge, because cells are 2D regions with distinct interiors [1]. No such rigidity is available in the abstract setting, consistent with $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ decidability remaining open.*

7. Technical priority and citation analysis

Lutz and Wolter [1] cite one paper by Wessel—[2], the DL Workshop 2001 paper. They do *not* cite the 2002/2003 technical report [3], which contains the more developed results. Their characterization of Wessel's work is:

> "We should note that modal logics based on the Egenhofer-Franzosa relations have been suggested in an early paper by Cohn [Coh93] and further considered in [Wes01]. However, it proved difficult to analyze the expressive power and computational behavior of such logics: despite several efforts, to the best of our knowledge no results have been obtained so far." [1]

This characterization is incomplete in several respects:

1. **"No results":** Even the cited paper [2] contains undecidability results for $\mathcal{ALC}_{\mathcal{RA}^{\ominus}}$ (ALC with role axioms in the non-disjoint-roles variant, via reduction from non-empty CFG intersection). The uncited technical report [3] goes significantly further: it proves decidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC1}$, $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC2}$, and $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC3}$; establishes PSPACE-hardness of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ and EXPTIME-hardness of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$; gives a complete axiomatization in hybrid modal logic; and identifies the coincidence obstruction with explicit constructions.

2. **The even-odd chain:** Lutz and Wolter's successor construction (using alternating markers along a *tpp*-chain to simulate a functional successor) is essentially the same as Wessel's even-odd chain [3]. Lutz and Wolter credit it to Marx–Reynolds [4] and Reynolds–Zakharyaschev [5], who used similar techniques in temporal logic. Wessel's application of the technique to RCC8 description logics—which predates Lutz–Wolter by three to four years—is not acknowledged.

3. **The grid construction and coincidence obstruction:** Wessel's Figure 10 [3] constructs explicit $n \times n$ grid models from RCC8 networks and shows they are composition-consistent. His Figure 11 identifies the coincidence obstruction: the composition table allows multiple relations at the diagonal point, so the grid cannot be enforced by a concept term. These are the same issues Lutz and Wolter must address (and solve, but only in the topological setting). The prior analysis is not cited.

4. **The undecidability boundary:** Wessel explicitly characterizes $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ as "close to undecidability" [3] and identifies the hybrid logic binding operator as the precise extension that crosses the boundary. This analysis directly anticipates the structure of the Lutz–Wolter proof: they succeed precisely where Wessel showed the abstract semantics fails, by exploiting topological rigidity in place of hybrid logic binding.

We emphasize that the Lutz–Wolter contribution is genuine: showing that topological rigidity resolves the coincidence obstruction is a non-trivial result. But the prior identification of the obstruction itself, the construction of explicit grid models, and the even-odd chain technique applied to RCC8 logics are Wessel's contributions and should have been cited accordingly.

8. Implications for $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ decidability

The non-transfer result has several implications.

Table 1: Comparison of technical ingredients

Construction	**Wessel (2002/2003)**	**Lutz–Wolter (2006)**
Even-odd chain via TPP/NTPP	[3], §4.4.2	[1], §8
Binary counter (2^n path)	[3], §4.4.2	—
ExpTime-hardness of RCC8 logic	[3], Thm. implicit	—
Grid model construction	[3], Fig. 10	[1], §8
Coincidence obstruction identified	[3], Fig. 11	—
Coincidence resolved (topologically)	—	[1], Thm. 8.2
Domino reduction completed	—	[1], Thm. 8.2

8.1. The standard reduction is blocked

The domino tiling reduction—the most common tool for proving description logic undecidability—cannot be applied to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ via the Lutz–Wolter route. The coincidence obstruction blocks it at the completeness step.

8.2. Other reductions are also blocked

More generally, every known undecidability proof for description logics ultimately encodes a two-dimensional grid. Grid encoding requires either:

- functional roles (not available: the role box is fixed),
- number restrictions (not available),
- role intersection or role composition beyond the fixed table (not available), or
- topological/geometric rigidity (available in L_{RCC8}, not in $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$).

As observed in [7], the patchwork property of RCC8 actively *resists* grid encoding: local consistency implies global consistency, leaving no room for the rigid global constraints that tiling reductions require.

8.3. The alternating-type trick: what $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ CAN do

While $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ cannot encode grids, it is structurally more expressive than $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ in one key respect: the $\forall TPP/\forall NTPP$ distinction provides a limited form of counting along chains. This is enough for:

- Exponential-length paths (binary counter, ExpTime-hardness);
- A "1.5-dimensional" structure: two parallel TPP-chains connected by PO rungs (the "$2 \times \infty$ ladder" of [7]);
- Monotonic broadcast: $\forall NTPP.D$ propagates D to all indirect successors.

But it is *not* enough for:

- Two-dimensional grids (coincidence obstruction);
- Consumable communication (monotonicity prevents it);
- Unbounded synchronization (required by domino tiling and PCP).

This gap—enough for ExpTime-hardness but not enough for undecidability—places $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ in a genuinely intermediate position. Whether the logic is decidable remains, after more than twenty years, one of the most interesting open problems in spatial description logics.

8.4. Relationship to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$

The non-transfer result for $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ is structurally parallel to the non-transfer of $L_{RCC5}(RS^{\exists})$ undecidability to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5} = L_{RCC5}(RS)$ (Remark 7). In both cases, the abstract composition-table semantics lacks a rigidity property that the concrete semantics provides:

Logic	**Concrete rigidity**	**Missing in abstract**
L_{RCC8}	Topological geometry of $\mathbb{R}^2$	Grid coincidence
$L_{RCC5}(RS^{\exists})$	Supremum closure	Supremum regions

Both $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$ and $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ remain below the known undecidability boundary. Whether they are also above the decidability boundary is the open question.

9. Conclusion

We have shown that the Lutz–Wolter undecidability proof for L_{RCC8} does not transfer to $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$. The obstruction is the *grid coincidence condition*: topological geometry forces the east-of-north to equal the north-of-east, but the abstract composition table does not.

This obstruction was first identified by Wessel in [3], who:

- constructed explicit RCC8 grid models (Figure 10),
- identified the coincidence gap (Figure 11),
- developed the even-odd chain for functional successors and the binary counter for ExpTime-hardness (Section 4.4.2),
- characterized $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ as "close to undecidability" (Section 4.4.3),
- identified the hybrid logic binding operator as the precise boundary (p. 43–44).

These contributions predate Lutz–Wolter [1] by three to four years. While the Lutz–Wolter result is genuinely new (resolving the coincidence in the topological setting is non-trivial), the prior analysis that *identified* the obstruction and *demonstrated* that it blocks the reduction in the abstract setting deserved more explicit acknowledgment.

The decidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC8}$ remains open. The coincidence obstruction is evidence *for* decidability—it shows that the logic resists the standard undecidability machinery—but it is not a proof. Settling

the question will require either a genuinely new undecidability technique that bypasses the coincidence gap, or a decision procedure that tames the infinite complete-graph models.

References

[1] C. Lutz and F. Wolter. Modal logics of topological relations. *Logical Methods in Computer Science*, 2(2):Article 5, 2006. DOI: 10.2168/LMCS-2(2:5)2006.

[2] M. Wessel. Obstacles on the way to qualitative spatial reasoning with description logics: Some undecidability results. In *Proc. DL Workshop 2001*, CEUR-WS #49, pp. 96–105, 2001.

[3] M. Wessel. Qualitative spatial reasoning with the $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC}$ family – first results and unanswered questions. Technical Report FBI-HH-M-324/03, University of Hamburg, Computer Science Department, 2002/2003.

[4] M. Marx and M. Reynolds. Undecidability of compass logic. *Journal of Logic and Computation*, 9(6):897–914, 1999.

[5] M. Reynolds and M. Zakharyaschev. On the products of linear modal logics. *Journal of Logic and Computation*, 11(6):909–931, 2001.

[6] J. Renz and B. Nebel. On the complexity of qualitative spatial reasoning: A maximal tractable fragment of the Region Connection Calculus. *Artificial Intelligence*, 108(1–2):69–123, 1999.

[7] Claude and M. Wessel. Decidability of $\mathcal{ALCI}_{RCC5}$: An EXPTIME upper bound via quasimodel elimination. Technical report, 2025.